

Browsing habits

Online browsing can be compared to dropping crumbs. A single crumb isn't a big deal, but many crumbs create a mess. Most users aren't even aware of what information they're giving away when browsing the internet. Continuously harvesting these small, harmless pieces of data can lead to serious privacy breaches. To prevent this, it's important to understand how user data is created and monitored.

Cookies

Cookies are small pieces of data that websites use to store information about a user's browsing session. Along with the IP address and search history, they can be used to create a detailed portrait of a user's habits and interests.

Privacy settings

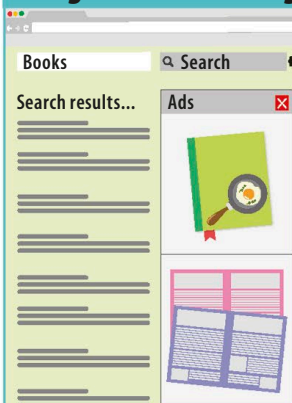
When installing a new app, many people hit the "I agree" button without reading the software licence agreement. This potentially makes it possible for apps to collect personal information without the user's knowledge, but with their permission.

IP addresses

An IP address is a 32-bit or 128-bit unique number used to identify a computer. An eavesdropper on a network can use this IP address to monitor the websites a user is visiting.

REAL WORLD

Targeted Advertising



Targeted advertising is designed to show people content they're interested in. If someone's browsing history contains a lot of travel websites, they might be shown ads for flight discounts and holiday packages. While targeted advertising isn't a violation of privacy, it reveals how much information can be obtained by studying search histories.

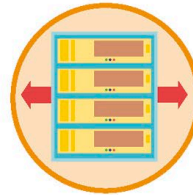
Prevention

The best advice for preventing data theft is obvious: only visit trusted websites; be selective about social media posts; if a problem is identified or even suspected, address it right away. For advanced protection, consider two-factor authentication (2FA) and encryption services. While it might be annoying to go through extra security steps online, in the long term, it's a small price to pay for maintaining privacy and preventing problems.



◁ Anonymous browsing

When browsing in a private or incognito window, no cookies are stored. Your search history, download history, and search queries aren't recorded and therefore can't be stolen.



◁ Proxy servers

These servers are used to hide the IP address, making it difficult to tell what websites the user is visiting. It's just like using someone else's phone to call a taxi – the taxi will still turn up, but they have no information about you.



◁ Clearing data

When using a regular browser, make sure you clear the history, cache, and cookies periodically. You can also configure the browser to automatically clear these after each browsing session.

IN DEPTH

Parental advice

Keeping kids safe online means teaching them responsible browsing habits. Update the browser settings to block adult content and periodically check their browser history. Have conversations about online safety. Parents of younger kids may also want to have access to their passwords, but for teenagers, there's a fine line between safety and privacy. If you decide to use GPS tracking apps or monitoring software, it's better to be open about it.